EXECUTIVE AI BRIEFING / DECISION MAP

AI AGENTS & AGENTIC AI

Select the right architecture. Control the authority. Prove the outcome.

THE DISTINCTION THAT MATTERS

AI AGENT

A model-directed decision unit that can select tools and next actions inside limits.

AGENTIC BEHAVIOUR

Goal-seeking execution that adapts to feedback; one agent or many.

Agent count is not an autonomy measure. A multi-agent system may still follow fixed steps.

01 CHOOSE THE SIMPLEST SUFFICIENT DESIGN

Four options, selected by the real uncertainty in the work

MODEL + RETRIEVAL

One defined answer

Summarise a specified file; explain a policy.

DEFINED WORKFLOW

Predictable sequence

Extract, check, route, then seek approval.

BOUNDED AGENT

Uncertain next step

Search, decide the next tool, check the result.

COORDINATED AGENTS

Genuine specialist benefit

Different roles or permissions; reviewed handoffs.

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USE AGENT LOOPS ONLY WHEN THE NEXT STEP MUST CHANGE WITH THE EVIDENCE.

02 SIX LEADERSHIP DECISIONS

The operating contract every proposed agent should be able to show

01

BUSINESS OUTCOME

Named process owner and a baseline for quality, time, cost and customer effect.

02

MINIMUM DISCRETION

Show why a prompt or fixed workflow is insufficient; compare alternatives.

03

ACTION PERMISSION

Allowed identity, data, tools and write actions; human approval and limits.

04

FAILURE CONTROLS

Bound time, retries and spend; stop, recover and record every action.

05

INDEPENDENT PROOF

Sample non-escalated cases; test silent mistakes, handoffs and prohibited acts.

06

RENEWABLE MANDATE

Assign operations, incidents and review; restrict or revoke when evidence shifts.

03 EXPECT FAILURES BETWEEN DECISIONS

Independent controls must check the completed outcome, not merely the agent's trace

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FAILURE MODE	WHY IT HAPPENS	EXPECTED PROOF
Wrong action	Tool, argument or evidence errors	Representative cases; tool allowlists
Broken handoff	Lost state, duplicate or stale steps	State and transaction validation
Untrusted content	Prompt injection through retrieved data	Least privilege; inputs not authority
Runaway execution	Excess retries, latency or spend	Iteration, cost and time ceilings
Silent failure	Errors that never reach a person	Independent sampling and audits

04 MEASURE WHAT AUTONOMY CHANGES

Do not confuse fewer escalations with fewer undetected mistakes

BUSINESS

End-to-end quality, time, customer result

CONTROL

Unsafe attempts, unreported errors, interventions

ECONOMICS

Full cost per acceptable result; realized benefit

RELEASE RULE **Approve only the authority, evidence and stop rights a real business outcome justifies.**



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